

CHAPTER ELEVEN

THE HOME INSPECTION

Ah, the home inspection—easily the scariest part of the home-buying process. It will be the subject of your nightmares. It will keep you up at night like a horror movie. (Home inspection. Home inspection. If you say it three times in the mirror, a certified inspector will appear behind you. Ah!)

This part is so important, we gave it its very own chapter.

A home inspection is a review of the property that gives you a snapshot of the physical condition the home is in at the time of inspection. Though it's not a guarantee that the home will be in pristine condition multiple years after purchase, it will tell you how everything appears to be functioning at the time of the inspection.

Here's how this process works: You make an offer on a house, and the offer is accepted. You go under contract. You celebrate. Then you have a limited amount of time to execute a home inspection and raise any objections about the current state of things. Based on your objections, the seller can either adjust their offer or hold their ground, in which case you need to decide whether the house's problems are worth the current price.

The reason the inspection is the Freddy Krueger of the home-buying process is because it's the biggest question mark you'll encounter on your journey—and it happens after you're already committed (and probably emotionally attached) to one house. Best-case scenario, the inspection will come back clean as a whistle. (Spoiler alert: We've never seen this happen in our thirty-plus years of buying and selling houses.) Medium-case scenario, there are a few small issues, but nothing big enough to lose sleep over. Worst-case scenario, big-ticket items like a bad electrical system, a plumbing issue, or structural problems can completely make or break your transaction.

Home inspections aren't cheap, and the buyer usually funds them unless otherwise stated in the contract. They are at least \$400 but usually more,